



Cold War

The Pursuit of national self-interest by both the USA and the USSR was a key cause of the Cold War. How far do you agree ?

Introduction: The Cold War emerged from the post-WWII power struggle between the USA and USSR, two superpowers with competing visions for global order. While ideology played a role, the pursuit of national self-interest – economic dominance, military security, and geopolitical influence – was the primary driver of the conflict. The USA sought to expand capitalism and secure markets, while the USSR aimed to protect its borders and spread communism. This clash of interests, more than ideology alone, defined the Cold War.

I. The pursuit of national self interests

After the end of WW2 the USA believed it had a strong role to play in shaping the world. To achieve their goals that were clearly pro-capitalist and to favour their interests USA had to impose their presence everywhere:

- ✦ Economic control: Breton-wood conference + GATT made the dollar the reserve currency ensuring American economic dominance
- ✦ Military expansion: The arms race and the Atlantic Charter 1941 were tools to contain Soviet influence and project US military power on a worldwide scaled. This was a key factor of the fear the USSR developed towards the USA as they considered those actions are imperialistic attacks.
- ✦ Political influence: Truman doctrine + Marshall plan - 47 - presented as humanitarian aid but were used to expand US sphere of influence and benefit their eco interests

The USSR following the end of WW2 rapidly feared the USA and focused on defending their national self-interests through securing their homeland

- ✦ Through Buffer zones pro-Soviet in the Eastern Europe
- ✦ Through the Comecon - 49 - a trade bloc to ensure their access to material and counter USA expansion (partly a failure)
- ✦ Through military posturing: Berlin blockade - 49 - and later the Warsaw pact in retaliation to NATO

II. Ideology as a second factor

We can say with certainty that the pursuit of national self-interests by both the USA and the USSR led to a rising crisis called the CW but we can also explore how ideological opposition can explain some tensions that largely contributed to this rise of tensions.

- ✦ Propaganda Tool: Capitalism vs. communism was marketed as a moral struggle, but decisions were driven by strategic interests (e.g., U.S. support for dictators if anti-communist)
- ✦ Proxy Wars: Conflicts like Korea (1950–53) and Vietnam (1955–75) were framed as ideological battles but were fought to secure spheres of influence.
- ✦ Fear and Distrust: The Truman Doctrine's "containment" and Stalin's "iron curtain" speech (1946) reflected mutual paranoia, but the root cause was competition for global dominance.

Conclusion: The Cold War was fundamentally a struggle for power, with the USA and USSR prioritizing their national interests – economic control, military security, and geopolitical dominance – fuelled by the fear of each other. While ideology provided a rhetorical framework, it was the pursuit of self-interest that shaped the conflict's trajectory. The legacy of this rivalry – nuclear proliferation, global divisions, and proxy wars – continues to influence international relations today.